



SIGMA OMEGA NU

LATINA INTEREST SORORITY

ESTABLISHED 1996

April 14, 2022

To the members of Gamma Zeta Alpha Fraternity, Inc.,

In summer of 2020 Sigma Omega Nu's National Board was deeply saddened and disturbed to learn about the sexual violence many of our sisters and others in the community had suffered. We are grateful for all who have come forward to share their stories and honor those who were not able to. As an organization, we do not tolerate any form of abuse, but in particular sexual violence due to its occurrence in our community. In order to stand in solidarity with all survivors, Sigma Omega Nu had decided to disaffiliate from all fraternities and organizations who actively or passively condone sexual assault, that, to our knowledge had standing allegations against them, and that had not made any actionable commitments for next steps. We stand unequivocally with survivors, recognizing that the time for a major overhaul that promotes lasting change is in front of us.

We recognize that our members come to us for support and a home away from home. In failing to be proactive, we have failed as a Greek community to keep our members safe. Our organization thereby is requesting a swift response, characterized by action and accountability from those members who have engaged in condemnable acts of sexual violence and/or colluded as silent witnesses to those acts. We continue to stand in solidarity with survivors and are actively working towards holding our members accountable. We strive to create a safer environment for the Greek community by improving our processes and requesting other organizations to improve as well.

As an organization, we were challenged to reevaluate our organizational procedures to ensure that our actions not only align with our values and priorities, but most importantly, prioritize the needs of survivors. We are rising to the challenges of addressing our own blind spots to prioritizing a safe, secure, and survivor-centered process, and responding when incidents of sexual violence are reported to our organization.

As such, we have held numerous discussion forums amongst our chapters and together, have implemented changes to our own legislative documents. While these discussions and changes remain active and improving, we have so far accomplished the following:

- Established a sexual assault protocol for when a member of our organization becomes a survivor of sexual assault which includes:
 - Education on how to listen to and emotionally support survivors of sexual assault

- Education on how to address immediate physical and safety concerns for the survivor
- Direction on how to escalate sexual assault allegation reports made by our members (against other organizations) to our National Board for further action and notification to the offending organization
- Chapter resources for reporting and responding to sexual assault incidents to our chapter's individual universities and local law enforcement
- Worldwide organizations available for outreach and resources for sexual assault survivors
- Updated our Chapter Bylaws to define sexual misconduct and specify that such actions are a punishable offense by our organization.
- Established a new judicial process for an event that involves sexual assault misconduct caused by a member of our organization. Most importantly, judicial consequences from this process are largely based on the expressed desired outcomes by the survivor or reporting third-party coming forward. Suspension of the accused members are to be immediate upon receipt of an allegation until the conclusion of the judicial process. The process for reporting a sexual assault event by our organization is currently being developed but will soon be widely accessible to the public.
- Established a sexual assault awareness and bystander training workshop requirement by all members of our organization, once every academic term (quarter/semester).
- Created a sexual assault awareness committee representative at each Chapter, and a sexual assault awareness committee at the National Board level, that was responsible for the above-mentioned changes. Moving forward, these committees will evolve into a permanent position on both the National and Chapter levels that will continue to collaborate, update, and reinforce these policies in the future.

We further commit to establishing the following in the upcoming months:

- Implementation of a sexual assault awareness and bystander training workshop requirement in our Pledgeship process.
- Dedicating a portion of our already required community service hours to bringing awareness to sexual violence and prevention by way of community outreach (i.e. tabling).

As an organization, we have and will continue internal reflection on how we can best educate and protect the members of our communities from the currently embedded abusive culture. However, we cannot create lasting change on our own and call on your organization to rise to the same occasion. Therefore we, the Sisters of Sigma Omega Nu, Inc. request that Gamma Zeta Alpha engage in similar processes at a national level in order to re-affiliate with our organization.

In order for our organization to re-affiliate with Gamma Zeta Alpha, we have compiled a list of requirements for your organization:

- Dedicate a portion of required community service hours to bring awareness to sexual violence and prevention. This can be fulfilled by partnering with local or national organizations to distribute educational materials (i.e. tabling on campus or in the community) and/or hosting community workshops.
- Add education to your Intake Process for members to renew yearly. This education should include attending and hosting SA-related workshops. These workshops should include but are not limited to: prevention, bystander intervention, consent, sexual harassment, rape culture, and supporting survivors.
- Create and/or update your organization's policy against sexual assault to be survivor informed. This policy should
 - address cases if/when organizational members are accused of committing or being a bystander of sexual assault
 - protect members who report other members from retaliation
 - provide guidance for reporting cases to Title IX, law enforcement, and others
 - provide resources for survivors
 - create a survivor-informed judicial process for those who commit or are bystanders of sexual assault. Judicial outcomes shall be in accordance with the survivor's suggested outcomes (i.e., suspension/delettering of members, etc.).
 - require notification of all allegations to the chapter's respective university
- Create and regularly moderate an anonymous reporting system, available to members and non-members.
- Create a National Officer position to oversee completion of these requirements or assign a current National Officer to oversee these responsibilities.
- Compile a report of all allegations and disclose findings to the chapters. The report can include data points regarding prevalence at certain chapters to be used in targeted interventions at the chapter level, potentially resulting in suspension or deactivation of Chapters.

Should you have completed the requirements, we ask that you email us to set up a meeting to review completion. Should all requirements be completed, we agree to provisionally reaffiliate - allowing our organizations/chapters to reaffiliate at a professional level (i.e., personal/professional development workshops, cultural events, community service). During this time all social events would be prohibited. Depending on the time of year, this probationary status would be a minimum of five months. If you would like to review the requirements above, our National Board is more than willing to set up a meeting to discuss further. Should we not hear back, we will maintain disaffiliation from your organization.

As an organization, we make a commitment to restorative justice and look forward to hearing from you regarding what steps will be taken in order to move forward and rebuild trust. We believe that

stopping sexual violence begins with all of us, and we ask for collective accountability. We ask that you stand with sexual assault survivors. We ask you to read and distribute this letter to all of your members. We would like your organization to recognize that we must all stand up and take measures to hold perpetrators accountable.

In community,

The Sisters of Sigma Omega Nu, Latina Interest Sorority Inc.